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UNIZIK FRESHER EDITION | 2026

HIS 101: Nigerian History to 1960 - States, Trade and Conquest

Chronology, evidence and the arguments historians actually have

FACULTY PRIMER

Faculty Primer

Faculty of Arts
History & International Studies | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

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Why this pack exists

This pack gives you the chronology first-year history demands, then shows the arguments behind it: pre-colonial state formation, the trans-Saharan and Atlantic trades, the mechanics of colonial conquest, indirect rule, and the nationalist movement up to independence.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Build a defensible chronology of Nigerian history to 1960.
- Compare pre-colonial political systems without ranking them.
- Explain how colonial administration reshaped economy and society.
- Evaluate competing historical interpretations.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Chronology you must hold

Dates are the skeleton of a history answer.

- Pre-colonial states: Kanem-Bornu, the Hausa city-states, Oyo, Benin, the Igbo segmentary societies.
- Trans-Saharan trade and the spread of Islam in the north.
- Atlantic slave trade and its demographic and political effects.
- Legitimate trade in palm oil and the Niger expeditions.
- Annexation of Lagos (1861) and the Royal Niger Company era.
- Amalgamation of 1914, indirect rule, nationalist parties, and independence in 1960.

Comparing political systems

Comparison needs criteria, not adjectives.

- Centralisation: emperor, oba, emir, or council of elders.
- Succession rules and the role of lineage.
- Taxation, tribute and military organisation.
- Gender and age-grade structures in governance.
- Religion and legitimacy.
- Trade linkages between regions before colonial contact.

> **Avoid the 'stateless' trap**
> Societies without kings were not without government. Describe the institutions that actually governed - councils, age grades, title societies.

Colonial rule and its arguments

Know the debate and its evidence.

- Indirect rule relied on existing authorities and reshaped them in the process.
- Cash crops, rail and taxation integrated Nigeria into an export economy.
- Mission education produced a new elite with its own grievances.
- Nationalism moved from cultural assertion to party politics.
- Historiographical debate: colonial emphasis versus African agency.
- Use primary sources critically: who wrote, for whom, and why?

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. Why is 1914 significant in Nigerian history?

Answer: The Northern and Southern Protectorates were amalgamated into a single colonial administration, with consequences for later federal structure.

2. Why is 'stateless society' a misleading term?

Answer: Igbo and similar societies had governance through councils, age grades and title societies rather than a centralised monarchy.

3. What did indirect rule do to traditional authority?

Answer: It used existing authorities for colonial administration while transforming their power, legitimacy and accountability.

4. Name two effects of the Atlantic slave trade on Nigerian societies.

Answer: Population loss and political disruption through raiding; economic reorientation toward slave supply and later legitimate trade.

5. What does African agency mean in historiography?

Answer: Attention to Africans as decision-makers and initiators, not only as respondents to European action.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Build a dated timeline from 1000 to 1960.
- [ ] Draw a comparison table of three pre-colonial systems.
- [ ] Map trade routes and their commodities.
- [ ] Read one primary source and identify its author's interest.
- [ ] Write an essay plan with a clear thesis.
- [ ] Learn five nationalist figures and their positions.
- [ ] Practise a document question under timed conditions.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

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YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date: